

Discernment and Self-Appropriation

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Discernment and Self-Appropriation: Ignatius of Loyola and Bernard Lonergan, S.J.

PATRICK H. BYRNE *

Abstract

Bernard Lonergan's vocation as a Jesuit was central to his entire life's work, although this is not well known. This essay shows the indebtedness of Lonergan's method of self-appropriation owes a great deal to Ignatian spiritual practices. In particular, it shows how Ignatian prayer and Lonergan's account of the structures of consciousness mutually enhance one another. In particular, it concentrates on how prayer is a transforming encounter between Christ and the one praying.

Keywords: Christian philosophy, consciousness, ignatian spirituality, Lonergan, prayer, self-appropriation.

Bernard Lonergan's vocation as a Jesuit was central to his entire life's work. This connection would be far from obvious to almost anyone who had just begun studying Lonergan's writings, and it has escaped notice even of some very advanced scholars of his work. Lonergan first came to prominence in the 1960s, and at that time was known for his difficult and highly intellectual writings on insight, knowledge, science, objectivity, being, metaphysics and his proof for the existence of God. Later his extensive writings on meaning softened somewhat the impression of abstractness made by his earlier work, but even those later writings did not seem related to the tradition of Ignatian spirituality in any obvious way.

Two notable exceptions however were the late Robert Doran, S.J. and Gordon Rixon, S.J. Doran drew attention to the "tone" of *Insight*, and its resemblance to the experience that Ignatius called "consolation." As he put it:

This consolation is related to an illumination that *Insight* can effect: in fact this world *is* intelligible, things *do* hold together, we *can* make sense of the universe and of our lives, we *can* overcome the fragmentation of

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knowledge, we *can* make true judgments, we *can* make good decisions, we *can* transcend ourselves to what is and to what is good.¹

Along somewhat different lines, Rixon emphasized the tacit importance of mystical experience in Lonergan's work. Drawing from Lonergan's unpublished writings, he showed how the Ignatian exercises influenced Lonergan and compared him with other thinkers who treated mysticism more explicitly.²

This is not to say that Lonergan explicitly thought of himself as advancing of Ignatian exercises. But there are several indications that Lonergan's involvement as a Jesuit with the spiritual exercises influenced how he approached philosophy and theology. He wrote explicitly about the Ignatian spiritual exercises in at least two places. One came in comments about a lecture that he attended in 1975 or 1976 about the spiritual exercises given by fellow Jesuit, Harvey Egan, S.J. Lonergan wrote:

I had been hearing those words [from the spiritual exercises] since 1922 at the annual retreats made by Jesuits preparing for the priesthood. They occur in St. Ignatius's "Rules for the Discernment of Spirits in the Second Week of the Exercises." But now, after fifty-three years, I began for the first time to grasp what they meant... What I was learning was that the Ignatian *examen conscientiae* might mean not an examination of conscience but an examination of consciousness... I was seeing that "consolation" and "desolation" named opposite answers to the question, How do you feel when you pray?³

Here Lonergan came to recognize explicitly connections between his philosophical explorations of human consciousness and the Ignatian spiritual exercises, connections that I believe were percolating implicitly for many years. Three decades earlier in notes entitled "Grace and the Spiritual Exercises of St. Ignatius" Lonergan sought to understand how

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1. Robert M. Doran, "Lonergan's Ethics and Ignatian Election," 2008, 6; accessed at <http://www.lonerganresource.com/pdf/books/1/33%20-%20Lonergan's%20Ethics%20and%20Ignatian%20Election.pdf>, 6/27/2013. See also his "Ignatian Themes in the Thought of Bernard Lonergan: Revisiting a Topic that Deserves Further Reflection," Lonergan Workshop, 19 (2006), 83-106.
 2. For a parallel study of the influences of the Ignatian exercises on Lonergan's thought, see Gordon Rixon, S.J., "Bernard Lonergan and Mysticism," *Theological Studies*, 62 (2001), 479-497.
 3. "Bernard Lonergan to Thomas O'Malley," *Method: Journal of Lonergan Studies*, 20 (2002), 81-82.

a revitalized theology might illuminate the place of grace in the spiritual exercises.⁴ He proposed that the spiritual exercises are concerned with the grace that makes people “more and more fully *and* [ever] more consciously living members of Christ Jesus.” According to Lonergan, this seemingly evident fact had been obscured by the state of theology of that day, which had lost its ability to illuminate scripture or life “due to the influence on it of conceptualism.”⁵

Speaking personally, I had no notion of the deep connection between Lonergan’s philosophical method and his formation as a Jesuit until Mark Morelli published Lonergan’s essay, “The Mediation of Christ in Prayer” in 1996.⁶ Morelli transcribed and edited this essay from a recorded lecture that Lonergan originally gave in 1963 at the Thomas More Institute in Montreal. In what follows I will examine how this essay illuminates the intrinsic connections between the Ignatian spiritual practices and Lonergan method of self-appropriation.

The Question of Christ as Mediator

Lonergan’s essay is a profound exploration of what it means for Christ to be Mediator. There is a pervasive shared interpretation of this Christian belief, which is called “substitutionary penal atonement.” According to this interpretation, Christ is Mediator because he stands in between us and God the Father. The Father is enraged at the sinfulness of humanity, and out of His infinite sense of justice, wants to cast us into eternal damnation as the punishment we deserve. Christ stands in between the Father’s rage

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4. Bernard Lonergan, “Grace and the Spiritual Exercises of St. Ignatius,” *Method: Journal of Lonergan Studies*, 21 (2003), 89-99; cited hereafter as “Grace and the Spiritual Exercises.” The editor’s comments accompanying these “notes” suggest that they were probably written between 1947-53, possibly for a lecture to a group of Jesuits, that never actually took place. See *ibid*, 100-105.
 5. “Grace and the Spiritual Exercises,” 89. Lonergan regarded conceptualism as one of the greatest aberrations in the philosophy of history, and dedicated much of his work to reversing its influences.
 6. Bernard Lonergan, “The Mediation of Christ in Prayer,” in *Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan: Philosophical and Theological Papers 1958–1964* (volume 6), (edited by Robert C. Croken, Frederick E. Crowe and Robert M. Doran), (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1996), 160-182. Originally published in *Method: Journal of Lonergan Studies*, 2:1 (March 1996), 1-20. The original published version incorporated Lonergan’s notes from a different presentation, which were moved into footnotes in the *Collected Works* edition. References in this article will be to the *Collected Works* edition and cited hereafter as “Mediation Prayer.”

and us, pleading for us to be forgiven. The furious Father can only accede to this plea if justice is served somehow. Justice is fulfilled by Christ dying in our place. This interpretation may find some support in orthodox Freudian psychology, but it is very problematic Christian theology, even though many Christians have subscribed to it over the centuries. Yet this is not the only interpretation of Christ as mediator, as theologians have struggled with the tensions between this interpretation and a vast number of important passages from Scripture that seem inconsistent with it.

In his essay, Lonergan put forward a profoundly different vision about the role of Christ as Mediator. It is a vision of Christ as Mediator of something that is immediate in us. It is a vision that grew out of his extensive scholarly work and teaching at the Gregorian University and, I believe, also out of his formation in Jesuit spirituality. In his scholarly work and teaching he studied the history of Christian thought about grace, Christ as God Incarnate, the Trinity, and other related issues. In doing so, he often took the thought of Thomas Aquinas as his guide. But in this essay Lonergan was not offering a course in systematic theology about these doctrines. Instead, he was communicating something about prayer that grew out of out of those prior scholarly efforts.

The Immediacy of Consciousness and Self-Mediation

Because he was endeavoring to communicate, Lonergan did not begin with a theory about Christ as Mediator, but instead with something immediate about us as human beings. He wrote:

Each of us is to himself [or herself] something immediate: oneself as one is, [oneself in one's living,] oneself as *Existenz*, as capable of a decision that disposes of oneself and yet is incapable of an absolute disposition ... It is oneself as a prior given to oneself, all the data on one's spontaneity ... It is not one's thinking about all that but each of us in his or her immediacy to himself or herself.⁷

The immediacy to which Lonergan refers here is the immediacy of ourselves to ourselves in consciousness. The word "consciousness" comes from the Latin roots meaning "to know *with*." We experience ourselves as given *with* and alongside whatever else it is that we are conscious of.

7. "Mediation Prayer," 178.

We may be conscious of a dog barking, but along with the experience of the dog's sounds, we are simultaneously and immediately conscious of ourselves as the ones consciously hearing those sounds. We experience ourselves as given to ourselves in the experience of being humanly consciousness. That is to say, we experience ourselves as gifts to ourselves.

A few years earlier in his book *Insight* Lonergan emphasized this prior immediacy and givenness of ourselves to ourselves as the fundamental dimension of human consciousness.⁸ It is fundamental because, as he put it, "you could not be present to me unless I was somehow present to myself."⁹ For "consciousness is much more obviously of this unity" of ourselves as given and present, than it is a consciousness of anything else.¹⁰ Being present immediately to oneself with along something else present to one is what is elemental and primordial in the experience of being conscious.

Consciousness of oneself as such is merely experienced and merely immediate. What is merely experienced is mere potency, according to Lonergan's conception of metaphysics.¹¹ As potency, human consciousness is open to all sorts of meaningful formations. As Aristotle put it, human intelligence is a potency that can "become all things and make all things."¹² Just which combination of intelligible meanings are taken on by any particular human being are open questions. The immediacy of ourselves to ourselves in and of itself does not settle any of these questions.

Lonergan uses the term "self-mediation" to characterize the processes by which we settle these questions of what we are to make of ourselves. At the most elementary levels, people are already mediating themselves simply in having sense experiences and paying attention to them. In the most elementary way, people form themselves and distinguish themselves from others by the sense experiences they have and do not have. Moreover, human sense experiencing is never merely passive. People organize their

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8. Bernard Lonergan *Insight: A Study of Human Understanding*, Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan, vol. 3, edited by Frederick E. Crowe and Robert M. Doran, (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1992), 349. Cited hereafter as *Insight*.
 9. Bernard Lonergan, *Understanding and Being: The Halifax Lectures on Insight*, Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan, vol. 5, (edited by Elizabeth A. Morelli and Mark D. Morelli, revised and augmented by Frederick E. Crowe with the collaboration of Elizabeth A. Morelli, Mark D. Morelli, Robert M. Doran, and Thomas V. Daly (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1990), 15.
 10. *Insight*, 349.
 11. *Insight*, 457.
 12. Aristotle, *De Anima*, III.5 430a15.

sensations into a wide variety of what Lonergan called “patterns of experience.”¹³ They make themselves into distinctive selves that have had these, but not those experiences, attended to some experiences but not to others.

People further mediate themselves by the questions they entertain seriously about their experiences, and by the insights that they arrive at through sustained efforts to understand. They give themselves certain formations by having insights. They become persons possessed of certain kinds of understandings. They move from being persons of understanding toward becoming wise when they engage in the self-correcting cycle of ever further questions and insights.¹⁴ Beyond even this, by making judgments, people commit themselves to the truth of at least a few things that they have arrived at through the self-correcting process.

In all these ways, people constitute and mediate the immediacy of themselves as given to themselves in consciousness. They mediate themselves into something meaningful and substantial, even prior to the self-constitution that takes place in deciding. By our acts of experiencing, understanding, judging we are changing, making and constituting the same self that is present as conscious in those very acts. This is what Lonergan meant by self-mediation. This is how we self-mediate the pure potency of ourselves as given and become people possessed of particular kinds of experience, understanding and knowledge. These stages in the process of self-mediation constitute what Lonergan called “cognitional structure.” Through the spontaneous performances of their cognitional structures over and over, people attend to experiences and add answers to particular questions through particular insights and judgments. They make themselves into persons who have particular kinds of expert knowledge about a limited number of realities. When people operate in this cognitional structure, they make the raw immediacy of themselves into the mediated reality of the actual persons they actually become. Lonergan’s discovery and description of the movements of this cognitional structure was the primary achievement of his early use of his method of self-appropriation.

But there is a great deal more to how we mediate and make the potentiality of ourselves into the persons we actually become. Beyond knowing the realities of our worlds and ourselves that comes from exercising our cognitional structure, there are the still further questions about what we should do in light of such knowledge and about who we should become.

13. *Insight*, 204.

14. *Insight*, 311-12.

We mediate ourselves ever more fully as we come to insights about courses of action that we could undertake in the particular circumstances in which we find ourselves. We go still further when we ask questions about what would be the good of this or that course of action, whether one is better than all other goods we might undertake, and whether indeed any of these actions would be truly good. In and through this process, our feelings for values play the guiding role. If our feelings are properly attuned to what Lonergan called the normative the scale of value preference,¹⁵ the guidance of feelings will foster authentic ethical discernment. On the other hand, if our feelings are distorted by self-centeredness, complacency, rage, resentment, hatred or bias, then our distorted feelings will corrupt and derail that process.

This is because our feelings of intentional response either reinforce or subvert our questions and judgments about the values of what we should do. Just as is the case in the self-correcting cycle of knowing what is real, so also the self-correcting cycle of knowing what I should do reaches its proper limit when all further pertinent questions are answered and form the bases for objective judgments of value. Beyond that, the mediation of our immediacy reaches its culmination when we decide and act on the basis of authentic judgments of what is the most valuable and right thing to do. It is with our decisions that we ultimately mediate the immediacy of ourselves into our lives as we actually live. If we arrive at objective judgments of what it is right to do and act accordingly, we make ourselves into increasingly authentic, noble, virtuous persons. But insofar as we subvert that self-correcting process and arrive at distorted and false judgments, or to the extent we turn away from how we know we should act, we corrupt and disfigure ourselves and our lives. I have used the term, “the structure of ethical intentionality,”¹⁶ to name this expansion of Lonergan’s cognitional structure into the realms of ethical deliberating, feeling, value judging, deciding and acting. It is by means of the combination of cognitional and ethical intentionality structures that people mediate their immediacies into the lives that they actually live.

But how will we decide to “dispose” of this given immediacy of ourselves, as Lonergan puts it? How will we mediate the immediacy of

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15. Bernard Lonergan, *Method in Theology, Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan*, vol. 14, edited by Robert M. Doran and John D. Dadlosky, (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2017), 32-33; cited hereafter as *MT*.
 16. Patrick H. Byrne, *The Ethics of Discernment: Lonergan’s Foundations for Ethics*, (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2016), 95-117. Cited hereafter as *EoD*.

ourselves as given to ourselves? What are we to do with this immediacy, this gift of ourselves to ourselves? What decision should we make? As Lonergan puts it, we are already “disposing” the immediacy of ourselves, even prior to deliberately deciding what to make of ourselves. Yet our self-mediation reaches a climax when we examine ourselves and deliberately choose who we will become. I will return to these questions later in this essay. But before doing so, a few more clarifications are necessary.

Unconditional Love as Immediate and Mediated

Lonergan continues his essay by drawing attention to yet another dimension of the immediacy of ourselves to ourselves. He writes:

Now *in* that immediacy there are supernatural realities that do not pertain to our nature, that result from the communication to us of Christ's life. ... That is our reality, the higher part of our reality. It is something *in* us that is immediate and becomes mediated by the life of prayer.¹⁷

In other words, Lonergan identifies another dimension that is present within the immediacy of ourselves to ourselves. Our consciousness includes within it, as “part of our reality,” a higher part that somehow is Christ's life. Eight years later in *Method in Theology*, Lonergan amplified what he meant by this dimension of immediacy dwelling within our self-consciousness. There he called it “religious experience” and characterized it as “the dynamic state” of “being in love in an unrestricted fashion ... without limits or qualifications or conditions or reservations.”¹⁸ When people are in love the experience of being in love is not always at the forefront of their consciousnesses, but it is always present. When it does come to the fore, it is experienced intensely. Yet being in love *in an unrestricted fashion* is a form of consciousness like no other. No words can fully capture the immediacy of this dimension of our consciousness. “To say that this dynamic state is conscious is not to say that it is known. For consciousness is just experience ... Because the dynamic state is conscious without being known, it is an experience of mystery.”¹⁹ Still,

17. “Mediation Prayer,” 178-79, emphasis added.

18. Bernard Lonergan, *Method in Theology*, (New York: Herder and Herder, 1972), 105-106; cited hereafter as *MT*.

19. *MT*, 101-102.

it is a dimension *in* the experienced immediacy of oneself to oneself. It is the immediacy of oneself that is consciously experienced as being in love unconditionally. For it is still oneself who is *in* love, who experiences herself or himself as present in the consciousness of being in love in an unrestricted fashion. Being conscious in this way, one is still experiencing oneself as immediately present to oneself in the immediacy of this mysterious experience.²⁰

By the time of *Method in Theology* Lonergan also shifted from speaking of the supernatural dimension in our immediacy in terms of Christ to emphasis on the indwelling of the Holy Spirit.²¹ He drew support for this claim from St. Paul's letter to the Romans. "It is God's love flooding our hearts through the Holy Spirit given to us (Rom. 5:5)."²² While Lonergan shifted the language from Christ to the Holy Spirit, the immediate reality remains the same. The visible mission of Christ works toward the same objective as the invisible mission of the Spirit, namely, to communicate the reality of God's unconditional love to the consciousness of every human being, and to draw all humanity out of sinfulness into communion with the Divine Trinity.

Just as with the immediacy of ourselves to ourselves, the immediacy of ourselves as being in love in an unrestricted fashion also calls out for self-mediation. This means that as people deliberate, some questions about the course of action they are contemplating will inevitably arise out of the experience of being in love unconditionally. People may fail to notice this aspect of their experiences as they deliberate, or they can try to repress it. But they cannot eliminate it from their experiencing or its implicit influences on their deliberations.

The history of religions reveals the various and complex symbolisms, languages and scriptures that people have used to mediate and make sense of experience of being in love in an unrestricted fashion. In *Method in Theology* Lonergan referenced the work of Mircea Eliade and Friedrich

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20. Max Scheler warned about a form of consciousness that annihilates the presence of selfhood and can turn into mob hysteria. Max Scheler, *The Nature of Sympathy*, translated with a new introduction by Graham McAleer, (New Brunswick, NJ: Transaction Publishers, 2008), 18-19.
 21. In the essay he did, however, also reference this dimension several times, as in "Being a temple of the Holy Spirit, a member of Christ, an adoptive child of God the Father is something that is ours essentially by a gift," and "Christ mediates between us and the Father, and the Holy Spirit mediates between us and Christ." "Mediation Prayer," 177-78.
 22. *MT*, 101.

Heiler among others to indicate these manners of mediating the immediacy of religious experience.²³

But in the essay “The Mediation of Christ in Prayer,” Lonergan focused on the ways that it “becomes mediated by the life of prayer.” In prayer people spontaneously use the same pattern of operations that they use in mediating the immediacy of themselves. Contemplative prayer is primarily a matter of absorption in and intensification of the experience of unconditional love. In the depths of contemplative prayer, one rests purely in that immediacy. But absorption in this mysterious experience also begins to work on and change the rest of one’s feeling life. Among other things, it elicits wonder. People wonder what it means. They wonder about how to respond. Although contemplative prayer primarily focuses on these experiences, at less absorbing moments in prayer, as people start to emerge from the throes of love and wonder, images and memories may come forward modified and illuminated by that love and wonder. Even sensations may shimmer in the light of being in love unconditionally. Questions about these transformed experiences follow, and insights may come to people in prayer. Frequently these are insights about something one should do, or insights into something about oneself or others. They include insights into what and who one might become out of this experience of love. Judgments and decisions are also sometimes made in prayer. People make decisions to implement or flee from the possibilities opened up by their insights. As people enter wonder, gain insights, make judgments and decisions in the light of the immediacy of mysterious love, they engage in the self-mediation of themselves as caught up in the immediacy of unconditional love. Thus the operations of cognitional and ethical intentionality spontaneously occur when people pray.

Ignatian Spiritual Practices as Mediating [self-reflective mediating]

Lonergan held that the experience of being in love in an unrestricted fashion is immediate in every human being, whether they engage in structured religious practices or not.²⁴ It is, after all, unrestricted love, and this means it is not restricted to those affiliated with a particular religious tradition. Likewise, the mediation of the immediacy of unconditional love

23. *MT*, 66, 85, 105-106, 256.

24. See Frederick E. Crowe, S.J., “Lonergan’s Universalist View of Religion,” *Method: Journal of Lonergan Studies*, 12 (1994), 147-179.

does not depend on any particular tradition of spiritual practice. People spontaneously employ at least some of the operations of cognitional and ethical intentionality as they respond to the immediate experience of unconditional love.

Nevertheless, the efficacy of the mediation of unconditional love can be greatly enhanced by spiritual practices. This is because spiritual practices are self-reflective rather than merely spontaneous. There is a famous story about a young person who asks a master, "What is Zen?" The master replies, "We walk." The young man replies, "But I already walk." The master replies, "But when we walk, we are *aware* that we are walking." It is this attentiveness and reflectiveness that differentiates spiritual exercises from spontaneous mediation of the immediacy of oneself as being in love unconditionally.

In his essay, Lonergan develops this greater the reflectiveness, and here one can discern the influences of Ignatian spirituality. He writes that, in mediating the immediacy of being in love in an unrestricted fashion, what we mediate

is Christ, not as apprehended by the apostles ... it is our *own* apprehension of him ... We put on Christ in our own way, in accord with our own capacities, and individuality, in response to our own needs and failings. It has its foundation in tradition and revelation, but it arises from what is immediate in the subject."²⁵

The Ignatian spiritual exercises are dedicated to discerning just what it is that Christ is communicating to each person in all of her or his unique personality. The primary objective of the exercises is to assist each person individually in making decisions in conformity with God's will.²⁶ But just what does it mean to speak of "God's will"? In his scholarly studies of Ignatius' spiritual writings, Jules Toner, S.J. argues that according to Ignatius, God's will is "to give us greater glory," which means God wills for us to participate in, indeed to be in union with, the unconditional love and goodness that is the glory of God – the "uncreated glory" that God is.²⁷ Ignatius constructed his exercises to help people discover that this really is also their own deepest desire, and that this is what they themselves most

25. "Mediation Prayer," 180.

26. The following paragraphs are adapted from *EoD*, 24-25.

27. Jules J. Toner, S.J., *Discerning God's Will: Ignatius of Loyola's Teaching on Christian Decision Making*, (St. Louis: Institute of Jesuit Sources, 1991), 15; cited hereafter as Toner, *God's Will*.

profoundly wish to freely choose as well. At bottom, God's will is what humans would freely choose – if they could be liberated from ignorance and distorting biases.

Toner shows that Ignatius understood God's will to be highly specific to each individual in her or his uniqueness. God's will is matched to the special qualities as well as biographical and cultural specificities of each individual person, and to the specific decision he or she is considering. What might be God's will for a person in one concrete situation will not necessarily be the same for another in different circumstances. As Toner puts it,

Ignatius is not proposing a way of finding any universal moral principle... Ignatius is rather proposing a way of finding God's will for this particular person with this temperament and character, with these gifts or limitations of nature and grace, at this certain stage of development (physical, intellectual, emotional, moral, religious). God's will thus understood involves this person's relationship with God and with other humans in this present situation with all its circumstances of place, time, culture, social structures, customs and so on.²⁸

It follows that the uniqueness of God's will for each individual person is also deeply connected to the glory of God in yet another way. In choosing to act in accord with the glory that God wills for the person individually, that person chooses to play her or his unique role in the historical circumstances in which she or he finds themselves. This involves the construction of social relationships, institutions, and cultures, through which the glory of all humankind is being brought about historically. Any particular human decision made in light of unconditional love, no matter how seemingly insignificant, is to be viewed as "God's positive will regarding something to be done *by* that person."²⁹ If the person actually chooses to act in that way, this decision contributes to the realization of God's glory in the whole history of humankind, and indeed of the evolving of all creation. Once again, Toner comments:

the greater glory is not to be thought of merely in terms of the immediate consequences of a choice or even in terms of the clearly envisioned long-range consequences, but in terms of the consequences for the ultimate glory to be achieved through the whole of history.³⁰

28. Toner, *God's Will*, 26-27.

29. Toner, *God's Will*, 26.

30. Toner, *God's Will*, 29.

Thus, for Ignatius, God's will is situated in the context of "an incomplete universe, an unfinished created glory" which is brought to realization through "the great glory of persons who have the amazing destiny and dignity of being [God's] intelligent, loving and free co-workers."³¹

Therefore, the habits of discernment developed through practicing Ignatius' spiritual exercises are the habits of reflectively mediating the immediacy of God's love and the immediacy of who I am given to be. In mediating those immediacies, I determine what I will make of the gift of myself to myself.

Ignatian Discernment and Self-Appropriation

The very same cognitional and ethical intentional structures of human conscious activities are inevitably operating during Ignatian spiritual exercises and discernment. For example, in contemplating a decision during the Second Week of the exercises, a person may be invited to imagine the alternative courses of action in detail, and then to consider whether the feelings that arise in depicting each course feel more like water striking a stone, or like water striking a sponge.³² Notice how this exercise first elicits images of sights, sounds and even touch, and then invites attention to associated experiences of feeling. Subtly and implicitly, this exercise elicits comparison of the feelings (what Ignatius called "spirits") about the potential courses of action to the feeling of being in love in an unconditional fashion. Next come the questions for insight ("What does it feel more like?") and for judgment ("Does it actually feel like that?") This exercise, then, directs people to attend to and reflect upon the interiority of their consciousnesses.

Something similar happens in other Ignatian practices such as the daily examen, composition of place (or "application of the senses") in the reading of Scripture, and the rules for discernment of consolations and desolations. There is first an attentiveness to interior experiences. For the most part this attentiveness brings about modifications in the constellation of one's feelings. But sometimes this is followed by questions that lead

31. Toner, *God's Will*, 18. Regarding Lonergan's account of one's role in the unfinished universe, see *Insight*, 470-71, 498.

32. See David L. Fleming, S.J., *The Spiritual Exercises of Saint Ignatius: A Literal Translation and A Contemporary Reading*, (St. Louis: Institute of Jesuit Sources, 1978), Rules for Discernment of Spirits, Second Week, VII.

to understanding and critical evaluation of one's understanding of those experiences. On the occasions when prayer is seeking discernment about possible courses of action, Ignatian practices direct attention to the feelings ("spirits") motivating the different options. Following meditative exercises Ignatius also directs attention to and offers cautions as well as exhortations ("points") about making decisions ("elections"), especially in choosing a way of life. These advisements stimulate the person to consider further questions until arriving at a sense of peace. While not explicitly stated, this sense of peace will be attained only when all the further questions have been satisfactorily answered about the whether the decision in question is in harmony with the unconditional love that God has given to the person.

So performance the dynamic structure of knowing, deciding and doing that Lonergan described does operate when people spontaneously mediate the immediacy of unconditional love and of themselves as given in consciousness. People do this spontaneously, but they also do it more self-reflectively under the guidance of Ignatian or some other tradition of spiritual practice.

There are, therefore, strong parallels between Ignatian spiritual practices and Lonergan's own method of self-appropriation, and it seems now apparent that Lonergan's own involvement with the spiritual exercises was an important source that led to his method. People do experience the gift of God's unconditional love even if they do not practice the Ignatian exercises or discernment. That experience does affect their other experiences, thoughts, decisions and actions. But Ignatian (and other) spiritual practices direct people to pay attention to the experiences of God's grace, and direct them to attend to their inner feelings, thoughts and decisions in light of that intensified awareness. Likewise, also people engage in the activities of the cognitional and ethical intentionality structures without adverting to themselves as doing so. But Lonergan's method of self-appropriation guides them in applying those very activities to the experiences of doing the same activities. As Lonergan put it, self-appropriation involves a "reduplication of the structure."³³ That is to say, it is an application of understanding, judging, valuing, and deciding to the immediate experiences of doing those very activities.

Self-appropriation itself is ultimately a decision with a considerable amount of preparation. As with Ignatian discernment, self-appropri-

33. Bernard Lonergan "Cognitional Structure," *Collection*, Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan, vol. 4, edited by Frederick E. Crowe and Robert M. Doran, (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1988), 208.

ation begins by engaging the internal experiences of consciousness. In the beginning stages of self-appropriation people pay attention to experiences of the activities in their own consciousnesses that play key roles in knowing, valuing and deciding. They may have previously noticed some of these activities, but few have noticed all of them. Frequently people experience this intensified self-awareness with a great sense of exhilaration.

Self-appropriation next turns to the more challenging tasks of properly understanding and appreciating the broadened experiences of these activities. Even for those who are more familiar with the diversity and rhythms of their interior experiences, few will have appreciated the full importance and interconnections among those experiences and activities. In this way growth in self-understanding and self-appreciation adds on to what increased self-awareness only begins.

Again as in the Ignatian spiritual exercises, people engaged in self-appropriation gradually discern that among the many activities in their own consciousness, a select few of these activities that play a more significant role in knowing, valuing and deciding than do the others. The most significant of all such activities are the inquiries that arise from the unrestricted desire to know and value, and the experience of unrestricted being-in-love. Recognizing the presence and roles of inquiries intensifies appreciation of the value of these most fundamental acts of consciousness, and also of everything they influence as well. It especially intensifies appreciation of the value of the one who is the agent and subject of these acts – the value of oneself. Self-appropriation moves beyond the experiences of oneself as performing these activities in these structured patterns, and adds explicit, insightful understanding and valuing of the interrelationships that are comprised by that structure.

Once this deepened sense of self-understanding and self-appreciation emerges, a person is then confronted with the challenge of choosing whether or not to embrace and foster their value. This is a challenge of deciding whether to be oneself or not. It is the challenge to decide in favor of the immediacy of oneself as a knower, valuer, decider and lover, or to choose instead some imaginary self, or to flee altogether from making this choice at all. As Lonergan put it, this is the moment of realization that in each and every one of our decisions we are “producing the first and only edition” of ourselves.³⁴ (Notice the intimate connection between this

34. Bernard Lonergan, “The Subject,” *A Second Collection*, (William F.J. Ryan, Bernard J. Tyrrell, eds.), (Philadelphia: The Westminster Press, 1974), 83.

pinnacle of Lonergan's method of self-appropriation and Ignatius' focus on the "election of a way of life.")

We do indeed make (or mediate) ourselves in every decision, but we do not always realize this explicitly. The practices of self-appropriation and Ignatian spirituality make this realization much harder to ignore. These practices intensify the need to deliberately choose to be oneself, or to refuse. These practices place an existential challenge before us, because they frequently intensify awareness of how much of a person's living has been at odds with this newly won self-appreciation. They reveal how difficult it will be to give up old ways and to form new ways of thinking, valuing and deciding in harmony with self-appropriation and the consciousness of unconditional love. The choices that this new self-appreciation presents to a person are the choices for or against what Lonergan called conversion (in its several forms).³⁵ If self-appropriation is pursued consistently, then, it tends to foster these forms of self-transformation or conversion toward living in fidelity with the value of being authentically a knower, valuer, and decider and lover.³⁶

Self-appropriation, then, does not teach people how to perform the activities of knowing, valuing, deciding or loving. Rather, self-appropriation begins from experiences of knowing, valuing, deciding and unconditional love which people have been consciously performing all along. For quite time people have been consciously engaged in and consciously, immediately present in knowing, valuing, deciding and loving and trying to live ethically (and even of trying to avoid ethical living), well before any explicitly guided exercises in self-appropriation. Nevertheless, self-appropriation does add something extra. It adds intensified awareness, better understanding, deeper appreciation, and strengthened commitment to the performance of what is best in these activities that people have been performing all along. Although everyone has been performing the activities of cognitional and ethical intentionality and acting spontaneously, few people have been doing these activities well, and fewer still doing them to perfection. As Immanuel Kant put it so keenly, "Innocence is indeed a glorious thing; but, unfortunately, it does not keep very well and is easily led astray." Hence he offered a "critical examination of our reason" in order to elucidate, refine, chastise and strengthen its spontaneous but untutored goodness in ordinary living.³⁷

35. *MT*, 238-44. See also *EoD*, 223-38.

36. See Joseph Flanagan, *The Quest for Self-Knowledge: An Essay in Lonergan's Philosophy*, (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1997), 8-15.

37. Immanuel Kant, *Grounding for the Metaphysics of Morals*, (James W. Ellington, trans.),

In like manner, Lonergan offered discernment as self-appropriation to aid our already operative efforts at ethical living. It adds new levels of self-awareness, self-understanding, self-appreciation and resolute commitment that will deepen their ethical worth.

Mutual Self-Mediation

There is yet another dimension both to the self-mediating of ourselves as being in love and to the self-appropriation of ourselves as self-constituting. Lonergan pointed out to the fact that our self-mediating is almost always “*mutual* self-mediation.” He argued that all human beings spontaneously use the same *operations and structures* of self-mediation described in the previous pages without being taught how to do so. Yet he also drew attention to the fact that the *materials and contents* that we use in self-mediation are taught, and these are not at all the same. In their processes of self-making, people draw contents from what is passed along to them by their families, teachers, neighbors, and their cultural and religious traditions. They use ideas, beliefs, feelings, and values that they have received from others as they perform the self-mediating operations of attending to experiences, understanding, judging, deciding and acting. Their familial and cultural institutions teach them how to attend to experiences of importance or ignore those that are considered unimportant or threatening in their milieux. They offer resources to facilitate insights and growth in understanding of those experiences. The inherited insights are especially needed in trying to understand how and why people around them behave as they do, and how to get along with them. The ideas and beliefs and feelings passed down from others enter into the processes by which they arrive at judgments and form beliefs. Such inheritances provide standards of criticism to be used in evaluating their own behaviors. These ideas and beliefs once originated with some predecessors who first noticed, understood, judged and evaluated such things.

In addition to being recipients of such heritages, people also bequeath to others through their actions and expressions what they have come to understand, feel, judge and believe. Every human being, therefore, participates in the extensive network of receiving and bequeathing that Lonergan calls mutual self-mediation. We do make ourselves by our conscious activ-

(Indianapolis: Hackett Publishing Co., 1981), 16-17 <405-406>.

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ities, but we do not do it alone. We depend upon others to assist us in our own self-making, especially the resources they offer to assist us in our self-mediating activities. We in turn pass along further expressions that will enter into the self-making of others through our own actions. Our self-mediation in fact is always engaged in mutual self-mediation as we receive and pass along inheritances.

Mutual Self-Mediation with and in Christ

This long exploration of self-mediation and mutual self-mediation has been preparatory to the main objective in Lonergan's essay: the role of Christ in our mutual self-mediation. Here Lonergan goes beyond his philosophical exploration of human consciousness and self-appropriation into the realm of prayer – more specifically, Christian prayer, and implicitly at least, Ignatian prayer.

[It is] not merely a self-mediation in which we develop, but it is a self-mediation through another. One is becoming oneself, not just by experiences, insights, judgments, by choices, decisions, conversion, not just freely and deliberately, not just deeply and strongly, but as one who is carried along. One is doing so not in isolation, but in reference to Christ... Consequently, there is an element not merely of personal development, but of personal development in relation to another person.³⁸

In one way or another, Christian prayer is always undertaken in relation to Christ. Most basically this means prayer in reference to the books of the Christian Scripture. For example, in the Benedictine tradition, *lectio divina* – the attentive reading of Scripture – is conducted self-reflectively with attention to the words of Scripture that stand out with special prominence in one's consciousness on a particular occasion. The Ignatian practice of "composition of place" (or "application of senses") was built upon this Benedictine tradition. It encourages the one praying to put herself or himself imaginatively into the location where the scriptural passage took place, and to notice how she or he is being affected.

Already at the elemental stages of such practices, the person praying is engaged in mutual self-mediation. Already this is "a self-mediation through another" insofar as the person is having new experiences that

38. "Mediation Prayer," 180.

arise in response to words inspired by the Holy Spirit or that came ultimately from Christ's own words and deeds. Sometimes prayer consists in no more than this – that we are transformed in our experiences and especially our feelings through our encounters with these words. But at times prayer also goes beyond this elemental level. Insights also can and do come as people pray along with Christian Scripture. At other times, clarity about a judgment or about a decision also comes about. For example, people receive clarity about resolutions to forgive or to seek forgiveness and reconciliation. In all this, people are mediating themselves through Christ, with his words and his actions in mind. Christ is guiding and facilitating and directing their self-mediations. Nor is this some kind of alien imposition on people by Christ. Christ's influence on us in prayer makes us ever more keenly aware of our own agency, our own deepest desire, our own authentic goal and true happiness. As Toner put it, through the mutual mediation by Christ in prayer, people discover what is really is their own deepest desire.

Lonergan goes on to insist that authentic Christian prayer really is *mutual* self-mediation in the fullest sense. This is because Christ, too, mediated himself as a humanly conscious being with reference to us. As Lonergan writes so poignantly, authentic Christian prayer is

a very real mutual self-mediation because Christ himself, as man, developed; he acquired human perfection. The human perfection that he acquired could have been quite different from the perfection that *de facto* he did acquire ... by his own autonomous choices, he was thinking of us and thinking of what we needed to be able to attain our own self-mediation. Just as it is by relying on, adverting to, the precepts, the example, the love of Christ that we attain our own self-mediation with reference to him in this life of prayer, so also the life of Christ himself was a self-mediation with reference to others, and the others are we and all [human beings].³⁹

Why did Christ so frequently go off by himself to pray, especially when crowds were clamoring for his approval and for his acts of healing? Lonergan would suggest that he went off to separate himself from distractions, to pray about us, to reach clarity beyond what *we think* we want in order the he might better understand who we *really* are, what we *really* need to become ourselves, and what stands in the way of our becoming our authentic selves. He prayed as a human being to seek guidance from

39. "Mediation Prayer," 180-81.

the Father and the Holy Spirit, in order to gain human insights, judgments and decisions about what words and deeds we most needed from him in order to become our true selves – to truly self-mediate the immediacy of selfhood and unconditional love that we have been given.

The Ignatian spiritual exercises are filled with meditations on the life, deeds and words of Christ. Exercitants are invited to contemplate what they have done for Christ, and also to place themselves before the two standards of Christ and Satan. There are contemplations of Christ's birth, his mother, his home in Nazareth, the episode of his being found by his parents teaching in the temple in Jerusalem, and his Sermon on the Mount.

But arguably the most profound moment in the Ignatian spiritual exercises comes in the fifth day of the third week of the Ignatian exercises, which is the contemplation of Christ's crucifixion and death (although such a contemplation is certainly not unique to Ignatian spirituality). Lonergan emphatically identifies this as the apex and fulfillment of the mutual self-mediation between Christ and human beings.

The human perfection that [Christ] acquired could have been quite different from the perfection that *de facto* he did acquire. If he sought the perfection that was suitable to him as a divine person, we would not expect it to have been the perfection of a person who lives a life of poverty and suffering, who lives in abandonment, unjustly and cruelly. Christ chose and decided to perfect himself in the manner in which he did because of us. We think of the cross primarily as the cross of Christ. But primarily the way of the cross is the way in which fallen nature acquires its perfection. We attain resurrection through death because death is the wages of sin, and death entered into the world through sin. It was because he was redeeming fallen humanity that Christ chose to perfect himself, to become the perfect man; by his own autonomous choices, he was thinking of us and thinking of what we needed to be able to attain our own self-mediation...

One can think of attaining perfection through suffering, which is the human lot, in terms of abstract principles, of overcoming evil by good, of transforming evil into good, of the general theme of death and resurrection. But instead of an abstract principle we have mutual self-mediation. We choose that way because, as I said, we choose the cross of Christ: 'If any man would come after me, let him take up his cross daily and follow me.' We think of the cross as the cross of Christ; but primarily the cross is something that belongs to all humanity. Christ chose it because of us, and we choose it because of him.⁴⁰

40. "Mediation Prayer," 180-81.

In prayerful meditation about Christ's death along with the reasons for which he endured it, we encounter ourselves in a very difficult way. We encounter ourselves as killing ourselves at least spiritually, sometimes even physically, often in really petty ways. We encounter ourselves as cutting off the self-mediation that would bring to realization the gift of ourselves to ourselves. We encounter ourselves as denigrating the gifts to us of other human beings and the non-human world as well. Lonergan wrote that "human authenticity is never some pure and serene and secure possession. It is ever a withdrawal from unauthenticity, and every successful withdrawal only brings to light the need for still further withdrawals."⁴¹ This is what happens in Christian prayer, especially prayer in contemplation of Christ's crucifixion and death. We begin to have new insights (even inverse insights) into ourselves. Our feelings begin to respond anew to memories of inauthentic actions with new feelings of shame and sorrow. We begin to form new judgments about what we have done, and what we should do in the future. We sometimes even form new decisions. But we also encounter ourselves as loved unconditionally, even loved unto death, by the one who wants nothing more than to release us from our self-destructive activities so that we can actualize the perfection that God in Christ wills for us. Rosemary Haughton once wrote:

Real self-knowledge of oneself is something that people can dare only when love has broken through. Without love, self-knowledge must be rejected because it weakens defences against the outside world.⁴²

The unconditional love communicated in Christ's acceptance of death on our behalf reveals to us a love for us beyond all limits, and frees us to recognize our inauthenticities, and to begin to make restitution for them. Christian prayer is an ongoing unveiling of our inauthenticities, and prompts us to mediate the immediacy of ourselves and God's love into growth into fuller life.

Conclusion

The practices of self-appropriation and Ignatian prayer both head us toward a common goal. Both lead us to an encounter with ourselves. Both

41. *MT*, 106.

42. Rosemary Haughton, *The Transformation of Man*, (NY: Paulist Press, 1967), 38.

confront us with a decision to authentically accept the gift of ourselves given in the immediacy of our consciousnesses, or not. Ignatian practices of prayer heighten the intrinsic relation of our self-discovery and our decision to the communication of God's love through Christ and the Holy Spirit. Self-appropriation heightens our encounter with and our decision for or against the self that is immediately present in all the activities of our cognitional and ethical intentional structures. Self-appropriation heightens our awareness and understanding of ourselves as attentive, intelligent, reasonable, responsible and loving. It invites us to use exactly those capacities to value and choose to live that way authentically. People can and do become profoundly transformed through Ignatian practices of prayer with no reliance whatsoever on Lonergan's practices of self-appropriation. Yet that transformation can become sidetracked and even corrupted by pervasive cultural assumptions that undermine authentic knowing and acting ethically. On the other hand, self-appropriation of the immediacy of oneself could, in principle, lead to the full flourishing of authentic human living. But given the pervasive and insidious ways that dramatic, individual, group and general bias corrupt our knowing, valuing, deciding and loving, this is impossible in practice. Thus there is the need for spiritual practices such as those of St. Ignatius Loyola to guide the mediation of God's grace, to heal the corruption of the biases, and to make authentic human living possible. Lonergan's essay shows the need of both forms of practice to mutually mediate one another. This is something Lonergan continued to elaborate in his scholarship and teaching until it reached its climax in his formulation of a *Method in Theology*. That method of eight functional specialties spells out the complex details that need to be addressed in order to achieve the mediating and mediated phases of appropriating both the abundance of ways that God has communicated divine love, and the vast richness of being human. Both mutually enrich, correct, and reenforce each other. But the full elaboration of this is the subject of another essay.

Appendix

Selection from Bernard Lonergan's "The Mediation of Christ in Prayer"⁴³

§5.2 Subjective Application

There is also another approach. In this we can see Christ as immediate and as mediator. Each of us is to himself [or herself] something immediate: oneself as one is, oneself as *Existenz*, as capable of a decision that disposes of oneself and yet is incapable of an absolute disposition; all that is to be known about oneself by analysis, by insight – yet not as so known, but rather as lived, as the *vécu* not as the *thématique*, as the *actus exercitus* not as the *actus signatus*. It is oneself as a prior given to oneself, all the data on one's spontaneity, one's deliberate decisions, one's living, one's loving. It is not one's thinking about all that but each of us in his or her immediacy to himself or herself.

Now in that immediacy there are supernatural realities that do not pertain to our nature, that result from the communication to us of Christ's life. In the Gospel of St John in the first part, 'life' is a recurrent theme that begins in the prologue – 'In him was life and the life was the light of the world' [1:3-4] – and culminates, perhaps, in chapter 10: 'I have come that they may have life and have it more abundantly. [John 10:10] 'Life' is the dominant theme in that first part; 'loving' becomes a dominant theme in the second part of John's Gospel. We are temples of the Holy Spirit; we are not our own. St Paul expresses this reality in an extremely vivid, vigorous, almost vulgar passage in 1 Corinthians 6:15-19: 'Shall I take the members of Christ and make them the members of a harlot? You are not your own – *non estis vestry* – you are temples of the Holy Spirit, you do not belong to yourselves.' Temples of the Holy Spirit, we are members of Christ: 'Saul, Saul, why persecutest thou me?' [Acts 9:4] Paul did not persecute Jesus; he persecuted the Christians; but there was an identification between them and Christ. We are adoptive children of God the Father.

That is our reality, the higher part of our reality. It is something in us that is immediate and becomes mediated by the life of prayer. It is not immediate in the sense in which our bodies and our souls are immediate to us. They are ours by nature. Being a temple of the Holy Spirit, a member of Christ, an adoptive child of God the Father is something that is ours essentially by a gift. Still, in the concrete, it is part of our concrete reality, and in that sense it proceeds through the mediation of prayer from being a sort of vegetative living to a conscious living. It can be merely a vegetative living, if one is in the state of grace, if one keeps out of sin, if one does good deeds. One does all this only by the grace of God. But its occurring only by the grace of God is not something with a label on it. It just occurs, and we do not stop to think. It is a life within us that goes on, that is promised to us by Christ, that fructifies in

43. "Mediation Prayer," 178-82.

us. Our ideas about it can be as vague and inconsequential as the ideas of Topsy: when she was asked how she came into the world she said, 'Ah 'spect ah just grow'd.' But this life of grace within us can become a habitual conscious living. When I say 'habitual' I mean that one is not thinking of it all the time but that one easily adverts to it, that one can be, as it were, distracted from worldliness in as easy and as spontaneous a manner as when one in love is distracted from everything except the beloved. It is not a matter of study of oneself or analysis of oneself. It is a living, a developing, a growing, in which one element is gradually added to another and a new whole emerges. That transformation is the mediation of what is immediate in us. What is immediate in us is that *de facto* we are temples of the Spirit, members of Christ, and adoptive children of the Father, but in a vegetative sort of way. That can move into living; and that is growth in prayer.

Just as we are immediate to ourselves by consciousness without any self-knowledge, and through our consciousness by philosophic study and self-appropriation we can come to a fuller knowledge of ourselves, so also what we are by the grace of God, by the gift of God, can have an objectification within us. What is immediate can be mediated by our acts, and gradually reveal to us in an ever fuller fashion, in a more conscious and more pressing fashion, the fundamental fact about us: the great gift and grace that Jesus Christ brought to us.

This mediation is potentially universal. The precept is 'Pray without ceasing' (1 Thessalonians 5:17). In loving our neighbor we are loving Christ. In making ourselves good Christians and better Christians we are loving Christ. In this process, which is universal, which can regard every act, though, word, deed, and omission, there is a complete universality, a possibility of the complete growth of every aspect of the person. And in that growth, not only is there the mediation of the mediation of the subject by his acts, but the acts have as always an object, and in that object the center, the focal point, is Christ. It is Christ, not as apprehended by the apostles, by Paul and John, by the church, by Christ himself, by the Spirit; it is our *own* apprehension of him [Christ]. It is, as it were, putting on, acquiring, our own view of him. We put on Christ in our own way, in accord with our own capacities, and individuality, in response to our own needs and failings. It has its foundation in tradition and revelation, but it arises from what is immediate in the subject. It develops in response to the capacities, the needs, and the growth of the subject.

It is, then, a self-mediation. There is the mediation by our acts of what is immediate in us through the grace of God. Though the object of those acts is not exclusively Christ – it is everything [about everything – being] – still, everything turns back to Christ in one way or another. That is, not merely a self-mediation in which we develop, but it is a self-mediation through another. One is becoming oneself, not just by experiences, insights, judgments, by choices, decisions, conversion, not just freely and deliberately, not just deeply and strongly, but as one who is carried along. One is doing so not in isolation, but in reference to Christ. The Father predestined us to be conformed to the image of his Son, through the merits of Christ, through the grace of Christ, through the example of

Christ. Consequently, there is an element not merely of personal development, but of personal development in relation to another person.

This development of the person in relation to another person is not only a self-mediation through another; it is a mutual self-mediation. It is not a mutual self-mediation like that between equals, between husband and wife, between brothers and sisters; it is not a matter of simultaneous mutual influence. But it is nonetheless a very real mutual self-mediation because Christ himself, as man, developed; he acquired human perfection. The human perfection that he acquired could have been quite different from the perfection that *de facto* he did acquire. If he sought the perfection that was suitable to him as a divine person, we would not expect it to have been the perfection of a person who lives a life of poverty and suffering, who lives in abandonment, unjustly and cruelly. Christ chose and decided to perfect himself in the manner in which he did because of us. We think of the cross primarily as the cross of Christ. But primarily the way of the cross is the way in which fallen nature acquires its perfection. We attain resurrection through death because death is the wages of sin, and death entered into the world through sin. It was because he was redeeming fallen humanity that Christ chose to perfect himself, to become the perfect man; by his own autonomous choices, he was thinking of us and thinking of what we needed to be able to attain our own self-mediation. Just as it is by relying on, adverting to, the precepts, the example, the love of Christ that we attain our own self-mediation with reference to him in this life of prayer, so also the life of Christ himself was a self-mediation with reference to others, and the others are we and all [human beings].

The life of prayer, the mediation of Christ in the life of prayer, is then, I should say, a mutual self-mediation. One can think of attaining perfection through suffering, which is the human lot, in terms of abstract principles, of overcoming evil by good, of transforming evil into good, of the general theme of death and resurrection. But instead of an abstract principle we have mutual self-mediation. We choose that way because, as I said, we choose the cross of Christ: 'If any man would come after me, let him take up his cross daily and follow me.' We think of the cross as the cross of Christ; but primarily the cross is something that belongs to all humanity. Christ chose it because of us, and we choose it because of him.

To carry the point further is, in a sense, a matter only of private meditation, of private living. The life of prayer is something on the level of what is lived, of the *vécu*, and any talk about it is thematizing it. But we have developed some notions, some categories: self-mediation and mutual self-mediation, applied to our own subjectivity, to what is immediate within us; and initially and fundamentally in a very obscure fashion in terms of objects: temples of the Holy Spirit, members of Christ, adoptive children of God the Father, which nevertheless have their subjective manifestation, their revelation in us that they are within us. These objects are the immediate in an ontological immediacy. And that ontological immediacy is promoted to a psychological, an intentional, immediacy through the life of prayer.

The life of prayer, then: Christ is mediator in the life of prayer

insofar as the life of prayer itself is a transition from the immediacy of spontaneous acts through the objectification of ourselves in acts. The acts of living and the acts within praying are referred to Christ. By that process we perfect ourselves, we become ourselves, we become autonomous individuals, we have a self-mediation that is related to another person. There is a similar process in the becoming of Christ as man; and in that case he was becoming himself with reference to us. In both cases the fundamental theorem, as it were, is transforming evil into good, absorbing the evil of the world by putting up with it, not perpetuating it as rigid justice would demand. And that putting up with it acts as a blotter, transforms the situation, and creates the situation in which good flourishes.

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